

Nervous System Regulation

Vagus Nerve, Anxiety Management & Somatic Tools

By Daniel Tesfamariam

A Comprehensive Health & Wellness Workbook

Medical Disclaimer

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Introduction

If you feel constantly on edge, exhausted, overwhelmed, or emotionally reactive, your nervous system may be dysregulated. This workbook teaches you to recognize your nervous system state, use evidence-based tools to return to safety and calm, and build resilience over time.

Chapter 1: Understanding Your Nervous System

The Autonomic Nervous System

Your autonomic nervous system (ANS) operates automatically, controlling heart rate, breathing, digestion, and stress responses. It has two main branches plus an important newer discovery:

Sympathetic: Fight or Flight

- Activated by perceived threat (real or imagined)
- Heart rate increases, breathing quickens
- Muscles tense, pupils dilate
- Digestion shuts down, energy mobilized
- Feelings: Anxiety, panic, anger, hypervigilance

Parasympathetic: Rest and Digest

- Activated when safe and relaxed
- Heart rate slows, breathing deepens
- Digestion resumes, repair processes activate
- Feelings: Calm, connected, present, content

Dorsal Vagal: Freeze/Shutdown

- Activated when threat feels inescapable
- Energy collapses, numbness, disconnection
- Feelings: Hopelessness, dissociation, depression, exhaustion

Polyvagal Theory: The Three States

Dr. Stephen Porges' Polyvagal Theory explains how our nervous system constantly scans for safety (neuroception) and moves between three states:

- Ventral Vagal (safe/social): Ideal state. Connected, calm, curious, creative.
- Sympathetic (mobilized): Fight or flight. Anxious, angry, restless.
- Dorsal Vagal (immobilized): Freeze or collapse. Numb, disconnected, shut down.

The Vagus Nerve

The vagus nerve is the longest cranial nerve, connecting brain to gut. It is the main nerve of the parasympathetic system. Higher vagal tone = better ability to return to calm after stress.

Signs of Good Vagal Tone

- Quick recovery after stress
- Good digestion
- Healthy heart rate variability
- Ability to socially engage
- Emotional resilience

Signs of Poor Vagal Tone

- Chronic anxiety or depression
- Digestive issues (IBS, bloating)
- Difficulty calming down after upset
- Chronic inflammation
- Social withdrawal

Chapter 2: Nervous System Assessment

Where Do You Spend Most Time?

Check the column that best describes your typical state:

Ventral Vagal (Safe)

- ☐ I feel calm and present most of the time
- ☐ I enjoy connecting with others
- ☐ I can focus and think clearly
- ☐ I recover quickly from stress
- ☐ My digestion works well
- ☐ I sleep well most nights

Count: ____/6

Sympathetic (Fight/Flight)

- ☐ I feel anxious or on edge most days
- ☐ My heart races or I feel restless
- ☐ I'm easily startled or irritable
- ☐ I have trouble sleeping (mind racing)
- ☐ I feel tense in my body constantly
- ☐ I snap at people or feel angry

Count: ____/6

Dorsal Vagal (Freeze)

- ☐ I feel numb or disconnected
- ☐ I have no energy or motivation
- ☐ I feel hopeless or stuck
- ☐ I zone out or dissociate
- ☐ I want to isolate and withdraw
- ☐ I feel heavy and want to sleep all day

Count: ____/6

Highest score indicates your dominant state. Many people oscillate between states.

Chapter 3: Vagus Nerve Activation Exercises

These exercises directly stimulate the vagus nerve to shift from sympathetic/dorsal states toward ventral vagal (safe and social).

1. Physiological Sigh (fastest reset)

- Double inhale through nose (short-short)
- Long slow exhale through mouth
- Repeat 3-5 times
- Works within 1-2 breaths for acute anxiety

2. Cold Water Vagal Dive Reflex

- Splash cold water on face (especially forehead and cheeks)
- Or: Hold ice cubes in hands for 30-60 seconds
- Or: Cold water at end of shower for 30 seconds
- Triggers automatic parasympathetic response

3. Humming, Singing, and Gargling

- Hum deeply for 2-3 minutes (vibrates vagus nerve in throat)
- Sing loudly (especially low notes)
- Gargle water vigorously for 30 seconds
- Chant 'om' or 'voo' sound

4. Extended Exhale Breathing

- Inhale for 4 counts
- Exhale for 6-8 counts (longer exhale activates PNS)
- Continue for 5-10 minutes
- Box breathing: 4 in, 4 hold, 4 out, 4 hold

5. Orienting to Safety

- Slowly look around your environment
- Name 5 things you can see
- Name 4 things you can touch/feel
- Name 3 things you can hear
- This tells your nervous system: 'I am safe right now'

6. Social Engagement

- Make eye contact with a safe person
- Listen to or use a warm, melodic voice tone
- Smile (even forced smiling sends safety signals)
- Hug or gentle touch from trusted person

7. Gentle Rocking and Swaying

- Rock gently side to side or front to back
- Use a rocking chair
- Sway with arms wrapped around yourself
- Mimics being held (primal safety signal)

Chapter 4: Daily Regulation Tracker

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 1

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Dominant state today (V/S/D): _____
Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
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Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

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Wins today: _____

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 5

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Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Wins today: _____

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Movement/exercise: _____
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Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Movement/exercise: _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____

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Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
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Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Social connection (Y/N): _____
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Wins today: _____

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 6

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
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Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
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Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 7

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Regulation tools used: _____
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Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 12

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Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 13

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Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Dominant state today (V/S/D): _____
Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
Time in calm/connected state: _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
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Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 14

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Dominant state today (V/S/D): _____
Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

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Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

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Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 15

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Dominant state today (V/S/D): _____
Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

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Time in calm/connected state: _____
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Wins today: _____

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Movement/exercise: _____
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Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

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Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

Daily Nervous System Tracker - Page 16

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Dominant state today (V/S/D): _____
Anxiety level (1-10): _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Regulation tools used: _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
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Time in calm/connected state: _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Body tension areas: _____
Social connection (Y/N): _____
Movement/exercise: _____
Wins today: _____

Chapter 5: Somatic Tools & Body-Based Practices

Why Body-Based Tools Work

The nervous system speaks the language of the body. You cannot think your way out of a dysregulated state - you must work through the body to signal safety to the brain.

Shaking and Tremoring

Animals shake after a threat to discharge survival energy. Humans can too:

- Stand with slightly bent knees
- Begin gentle bouncing or shaking
- Let the shaking spread naturally to whole body
- Continue for 5-15 minutes
- Notice what happens as you slow down

Grounding Techniques

Feet on Floor

- Press feet firmly into the ground
- Notice the sensation of support beneath you
- Rock weight forward, back, side to side
- Stomp gently if needed for more sensation

Butterfly Hug (bilateral stimulation)

- Cross arms over chest, hands on shoulders
- Alternately tap left, right, left, right
- Slow rhythm for 2-3 minutes
- Used in EMDR for emotional processing

Progressive Muscle Relaxation

Tense each muscle group for 5 seconds, then release completely:

- Start with feet, work up through body to face
- Notice the contrast between tension and release
- Takes 10-15 minutes for full body

Containment Visualization

- Imagine a container (box, vault, locked chest)
- Mentally place overwhelming feelings/memories inside
- Close and lock the container
- You can return to it when ready and resourced
- Useful for managing flashbacks or overwhelm

Chapter 6: Lifestyle for Nervous System Health

Daily Practices for Regulation

- Morning: Sunlight within 30 min (sets circadian rhythm, calms NS)
- Movement: Daily gentle exercise (walking, yoga, swimming)
- Nature: Time outdoors (proven to shift to parasympathetic)
- Connection: At least one meaningful interaction daily
- Breathwork: 5-10 minutes of intentional breathing
- Sleep: Consistent schedule, 7-9 hours

Nutrition for the Nervous System

- Omega-3 fats: Brain and nerve health (fatty fish, walnuts)
- Magnesium: Natural relaxant (leafy greens, dark chocolate)
- B vitamins: Nerve function (whole grains, eggs)
- Probiotics: Gut-brain axis support (fermented foods)
- Avoid: Excess caffeine, alcohol, sugar (all dysregulating)

Building a Safety Toolkit

Create your personalized toolkit for different states:

When Anxious/Activated (sympathetic):

My tools: _____

When Numb/Shutdown (dorsal vagal):

My tools: _____

For Maintenance (daily regulation):

My tools: _____

Chapter 7: Progress Review

Week 1 Review

Date Range: __/__/__ to __/__/__

Dominant nervous system state this week:

Number of days in regulated state: __/7

Tools used and effectiveness:

Triggers identified:

Recovery time from activation:

Sleep quality average:

Body tension level (1-10):

What helped most this week:

Week 2 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Dominant nervous system state this week:

Number of days in regulated state: __/7

Tools used and effectiveness:

Triggers identified:

Recovery time from activation:

Sleep quality average:

Body tension level (1-10):

What helped most this week:

Week 3 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Dominant nervous system state this week:

Number of days in regulated state: __/7

Tools used and effectiveness:

Triggers identified:

Recovery time from activation:

Sleep quality average:

Body tension level (1-10):

What helped most this week:

Week 4 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Dominant nervous system state this week:

Number of days in regulated state: __/7

Tools used and effectiveness:

Triggers identified:

Recovery time from activation:

Sleep quality average:

Body tension level (1-10):

What helped most this week:

Week 5 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Dominant nervous system state this week:

Number of days in regulated state: __/7

Tools used and effectiveness:

Triggers identified:

Recovery time from activation:

Sleep quality average:

Body tension level (1-10):

What helped most this week:

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How long does it take to regulate a dysregulated nervous system?

It varies greatly depending on how long dysregulation has been present. Some people notice shifts within days of consistent practice. Deeper changes take months of daily work. Be patient and consistent.

Q: Is this the same as anxiety?

Anxiety is often a symptom of nervous system dysregulation (stuck in sympathetic activation). Regulation tools address the root cause rather than just managing symptoms.

Q: Can trauma cause nervous system dysregulation?

Yes. Trauma is one of the primary causes. The nervous system can get 'stuck' in protective states long after danger has passed. Professional trauma therapy combined with these tools is recommended.

Q: Why do I feel worse before feeling better?

As your nervous system begins to regulate, suppressed emotions and body sensations may surface. This is actually a sign of healing - you're feeling things you've been numb to. Go slowly and seek support if needed.

Q: Can children benefit from these tools?

Absolutely. Teaching children co-regulation and simple tools like breathing and shaking helps build nervous system resilience early. Model these practices - children learn through watching.

Q: What is the difference between regulation and relaxation?

Relaxation is one state (parasympathetic). Regulation is the ability to flexibly move between states as appropriate - being activated when needed and returning to baseline when safe.

Q: Should I avoid all stress?

No. Some stress is healthy and necessary (exercise, challenges, growth). The goal is building resilience - the ability to handle stress and recover. Avoid chronic, unrelenting stress.

Q: How do I know if I need professional help?

If dysregulation significantly impacts daily functioning, if you have trauma history, if you experience dissociation, or if self-help tools aren't providing relief after consistent practice for 6-8 weeks.

Quick-Reference: Daily Regulation Checklist

- ☐ Morning sunlight exposure
- ☐ Breathwork practice (5+ min)
- ☐ Checked in with body (where am I holding tension?)
- ☐ Used vagal toning exercise
- ☐ Moved body gently
- ☐ Connected with another person
- ☐ Spent time in nature or outdoors
- ☐ Honored my nervous system's needs
- ☐ Practiced self-compassion

Notes & Reflections

Use these pages to record your thoughts, observations, and insights as you work through this workbook.

Notes - Page 1

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 2

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 3

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 4

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 5

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 6

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Notes - Page 7

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Notes - Page 8

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Notes - Page 9

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Notes - Page 10

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Notes - Page 15

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Notes - Page 19

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Notes - Page 20

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About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a health and wellness content creator dedicated to making evidence-based health information accessible and actionable. Through carefully designed workbooks and guides, Daniel helps people take control of their health journey with practical tools, trackers, and strategies.

For more health and wellness resources, visit our Etsy shop for additional workbooks, planners, and guides covering nutrition, fitness, mental health, and chronic condition management.

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- Share your progress - we love hearing success stories

Thank you for investing in your health. You deserve to feel your best.